LessonPlan Career Roadmap

Defence Services (Army, Navy, Air Force, Sainik Schools, Agniveer): Class 6 to Career

LESSONPLAN CAREER ROADMAP
Compiled from publicly available sources. Items marked † should be confirmed on the official notification of the conducting body. Dates and rules change every year.

1. Pathway overview

Stage	When	Key decision	What it unlocks
School entry	Class 6 / 8 / 9	Sainik School (AISSEE) at Class 6 or 9; military school routes; join NCC in school	Early discipline, SSB-style training, entry to NDA later
Pre-board	Class 9-10	Stay fit; keep Maths and Science strong; NCC certificates	Agniveer (after Class 10), NDA / TES eligibility (PCM)
Entry after Class 10	After Class 10	Agniveer General Duty, Tradesman (age 17.5-21)	4-year service with chance of permanent enrolment
Entry after Class 12	After Class 12	NDA (3 services), 10+2 Technical Entry (Army TES), Navy 10+2 BTech Cadet Entry, Agniveer Technical / Clerk	Officer training with degree, or 4-year Agniveer service
Entry after graduation	After degree	CDS (IMA / INA / AFA / OTA), AFCAT, NCC Special Entry, technical graduate entries	Commissioned officer roles
Selection	All officer entries	Written test or JEE Main rank, then 5-day SSB interview and medical	Merit list and training academy seat
Career	Service years	Officer ranks, specialisation, second career after service	Command, technical, flying, legal and staff roles

2. Stage-by-stage nodes

Class 6-10: School-level routes

- Sainik Schools: admission at Class 6 and Class 9 through AISSEE (NTA). Both boys and girls can appear; seats are reserved for SC, ST, OBC and wards of service personnel.
- Rashtriya Indian Military College (RIMC) takes students at Class 8; details not confirmed at the time of compilation.†
- NCC in school and college builds discipline and gives certificates (A, B, C) that help later entries; NCC "C" holders can use the NCC Special Entry route after graduation.†
- Fitness and Maths matter: all officer entries test physical standards and, for NDA / TES / Navy BTech, Physics and Maths.

After Class 10

- Agniveer (General Duty): Class 10 pass with minimum 45% and 33% in each subject (reported); Tradesman: Class 8 or 10 pass.
- Alternatively continue to Class 12: choose PCM for Air Force / Navy / Technical entries; any stream is allowed for NDA Army wing.

After Class 12

- NDA / NA: UPSC written test plus SSB; see detailed card below.
- Army 10+2 TES and Navy 10+2 BTech Cadet Entry: need PCM and a JEE Main score; selection by rank, then SSB.
- Agniveer Technical (Class 12 PCM + English), Clerk / Storekeeper Technical (60% any stream).

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After graduation

- CDS (UPSC) for IMA, INA, AFA, OTA; AFCAT for Air Force; NCC Special Entry; Territorial Army and technical graduate entries.†
- Law graduates may apply for JAG; engineers for technical branches.†

Selection and training

- SSB interview: five days at a Selection Board. Day 1 screening (OIR and picture perception test); Day 2 psychological tests; Days 3-4 Group Testing Officer tasks and interview; Day 5 conference. Centres include Bengaluru. Then medical examination.
- After selection: academy training (NDA Khadakwasla, IMA Dehradun, INA Ezhimala, AFA Dundigal, OTA Chennai†) and commissioning.

3. Early school-level exams and routes

Exam / route	Conducted by	Classes	Details	Timing
AISSEE (Sainik School entrance)	NTA	6 and 9 (boys and girls)	Offline OMR; 150 min (Class 6) and 180 min (Class 9)	2026 exam on 18 Jan 2026; next cycle registration expected Oct-Nov†
RIMC entrance	Rashtriya Indian Military College	8	Not confirmed at the time of compilation	†
NCC (school and college wings)	NCC Directorate	School and college	A, B, C certificates; camps and drills	Joined at school or college
NMMS (scholarship test)	Karnataka DSERT / KSEAB	8	Single written test	Apply Sep-Oct; exam Jan-Feb

Tip for parents: for Sainik Schools, age and class rules are strict (Class 6: 10-12 years; Class 9: 13-15 years as on 31 March of the year, per the 2026 cycle). Check the NTA notice each year.

4. Entrance exams and selection

AISSEE (All India Sainik Schools Entrance Examination)	
Conducting body	National Testing Agency (NTA); exams.nta.ac.in
Eligibility	Class 6: age 10-12 on 31 March 2026, Class 5 passed. Class 9: age 13-15 on 31 March 2026 (born 1 Apr 2011 to 31 Mar 2013), Class 8 passed. Boys and girls for both classes (reported)
Pattern	Offline OMR; 150 minutes for Class 6 and 180 minutes for Class 9; section details not confirmed†
Reservation	Reported: 15% SC, 7.5% ST, 27% OBC, 25% wards of service personnel and ex-servicemen†
Frequency / date	Once a year; held 18 January 2026; application window and fee (about 850 for General) differ across sources†

NDA and NA (National Defence Academy / Naval Academy) - UPSC	
Conducting body	Union Public Service Commission (UPSC); upsc.gov.in
Eligibility	Class 12 pass (or appearing). Army wing: any stream. Air Force and Navy wings, and Naval Academy: Physics and Maths. Unmarried; about 16.5 to 19.5 years of age (birth-date window changes each cycle)†
Frequency / date	Twice a year (NDA I and NDA II); NDA II 2026 written exam was on 13 September 2026; next cycle notification expected around December†
Pattern	Written test 900 marks: Mathematics 300 and General Ability Test 600, 2.5 hours each; SSB interview 900 (total 1800); negative marking one-third†

CDS (Combined Defence Services) - UPSC	
Conducting body	UPSC; applications at upsconline.nic.in

Used for	Indian Military Academy (IMA), Indian Naval Academy (INA), Air Force Academy (AFA) and Officers Training Academy (OTA)
Eligibility	Unmarried graduates; INA and AFA need an engineering degree or BSc with Physics and Maths (reported; conflicting)†. Age about 19-24 (IMA / INA / AFA) and 19-25 (OTA); exact birth-date window set in each notification†
Frequency / dates	Twice a year. CDS I 2027: notification around 2-22 December 2026, exam 11 April 2027. CDS II 2027: notification about 12 May, exam 19 September 2027 (from UPSC calendar, subject to change)†
Pattern	IMA / INA / AFA: three papers (English, General Knowledge, Elementary Mathematics). OTA: two papers (English, General Knowledge)†. Then SSB, medical and merit

AFCAT (Air Force Common Admission Test)	
Conducting body	Indian Air Force; afcat.edcil.co.in
Eligibility	Flying branch: age 20-24 (up to 26 with commercial pilot licence); ground duty: 20-26 (as on 1 January of the cycle). Flying needs 50% in Maths and Physics at 10+2 and a graduation with 60%; technical branches need engineering degrees†
Frequency / dates	Twice a year. AFCAT 2 2026: applications 20 May - 19 June 2026, exam 8 August 2026. AFCAT 1 2027 notification not confirmed†
Pattern	Online, 100 questions in 120 minutes (General Awareness, Verbal Ability, Numerical Ability, Reasoning and Military Aptitude); negative marking; then AFSB and medical†

Agniveer (Agnipath scheme) - Army, Navy, Air Force	
Age and tenure	17.5 to 21 years; 4-year service including 6 months training; up to 25% of each batch may be retained permanently; about 11.71 lakh tax-free corpus at exit (reported)†
Education by post (reported)	General Duty: Class 10 with 45% and 33% in each subject. Technical: Class 12 with Physics, Chemistry, Maths and English, 50% overall and 40% in each. Clerk / Storekeeper Technical: 60% in Class 12, any stream. Tradesman: Class 8 or 10 pass. Navy and Air Force criteria differ and sources conflict†
Selection	Common Entrance Exam and physical / medical tests; pattern details not found at the time of compilation†

Indian Navy 10+2 BTech Cadet Entry	
Eligibility	70% combined in PCM and 50% in English (Class 10 or 12); must have appeared in JEE Main; unmarried. Jan 2027 batch: born 2 July 2007 to 1 January 2010; about 60 vacancies (reported)†
Selection	Shortlisting on JEE Main CRL rank, SSB interview, medical; BTech at Indian Naval Academy, Ezhimala
Timing	Applications for the Jan 2027 batch ran 29 May - 18 June 2026; next cycle expected mid-2027†

Indian Army 10+2 Technical Entry Scheme (TES)	
Eligibility	Class 12 with PCM, 60% aggregate; JEE Main score; unmarried male; TES-56 age 16.5 to 19.5. TES-57 (July 2027 course): applications reported 14 October to 12 November 2026†
Selection	Shortlisting on JEE Main rank, 5-day SSB, medical; four years of engineering training then commissioning

Other routes

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Route	For	Key details
NCC Special Entry (Army)	Graduates with NCC "C" certificate	Graduation with at least 50% and NCC C with minimum B grade; direct SSB call†
Territorial Army and technical graduate entries	Working professionals and graduates	Schemes change yearly†
Coast Guard, CAPF (BSF, CRPF, CISF, ITBP) and state police	Uniformed services outside the three armed forces	Not covered at the time of compilation†

Postgraduate and beyond (preview)

Exam	Body	For	Tentative timing
Staff college and service courses	Armed forces	Career progression	In service
CAPF (AC) exam	UPSC	Assistant Commandant in paramilitary forces	Once a year†
Defence PSU / DRDO / civilian roles	Various	After service or engineering degree	Per notification†

5. Scholarships and financial support

Scholarship	Provider	Who can apply	Amount	Window
Scholarships for wards of ex-servicemen and Central Armed Police Forces	Ministry of Defence / Home Affairs, state boards	Wards of serving, retired and deceased personnel	Varies	Typically after Class 12 results†
NMMS	Govt. of India via Karnataka DSERT	Class 8 in govt/aided/local body schools; family income up to 3.5 lakh; at least 55% in Class 7 (50% SC/ST)†	12,000 per year (1,000 per month), Class 9-12	Apply Sep-Oct; exam Jan-Feb
CSSS (Central Sector Scheme)	Ministry of Education via National Scholarship Portal	Top 20% of successful candidates in own board and stream; family income up to 4.5 lakh	12,000 per year for UG years 1-3; 20,000 per year for years 4-5 / PG	2026-27 portal opened 1 Jun 2026; one listing shows 31 Oct 2026 deadline†
Post-matric scholarships	National Scholarship Portal and Karnataka SSP	SC/ST/OBC/minority categories, income limits	Varies	Typically Jul-Nov†

Note: officer cadets at NDA, IMA, INA and AFA receive free training, stipend and education during training.†

6. Courses, training and institutions

Course / programme	Duration	Entry	Note
NDA: BSc / BTech at the academy then service academy	3 yr + 1 yr	NDA exam + SSB	Degree from JNU / affiliated; officer commission
Navy 10+2 BTech Cadet Entry	4 yr	JEE Main rank + SSB	BTech then commission in Navy
Army TES	4 yr + commission	JEE Main rank + SSB	Technical Entry Scheme
IMA / INA / AFA / OTA (after graduation)	1-1.5 yr	CDS + SSB	Commission as officer
Agniveer	4 yr	Agniveer entrance	Service then retention or exit corpus
Sainik School / Military School	Class 6-12	AISSEE / school-specific	Board education with military ethos

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Examples of institutions: National Defence Academy (Khadakwasla), Indian Military Academy (Dehradun), Indian Naval Academy (Ezhimala), Air Force Academy (Dundigal), Officers Training Academy (Chennai), Sainik Schools in Karnataka (for example Bijapur, Kodagu)†, RIMC (Dehradun).†

7. Career outcomes

Path	Job roles	Higher study / growth
Army officer	Lieutenant to General; arms and services; technical corps	Staff college, defence services courses
Navy officer	Sub-Lieutenant to Admiral; executive, engineering, electrical, education branches	Naval staff and technical courses
Air Force officer	Flying, technical, ground duty branches; pilot	Staff and flying courses
Agniveer and JCO / OR	Soldier, sailor, airman; Junior Commissioned Officer after promotion	Retention, skill and second-career pathways
Defence support and legal	JAG officer, medical (AFMC), education, engineering corps	Specialised service courses
Second career	CAPF, police, corporate security, civil services, teaching, PSUs	Exams and resettlement courses

8. Related umbrellas this one connects to

- Science PCM: NDA Air Force / Navy, TES and Navy BTech need PCM (see Science PCM document).
- Science PCB: Armed Forces Medical Services through NEET and AFMC (see Science PCB document).
- Law: JAG branches for law graduates (see Law document).†
- Aviation and Maritime: pilot and merchant navy routes (see Hospitality, Aviation and Maritime document).
- Sports: sportspersons can enter through sports quotas in services.†
- Civil services: UPSC CAPF and CDS overlap with graduate career planning.

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Items marked † are subject to confirmation against official notifications.

Stage	What to do
Class 6-10	Sainik School at Class 6 / 9 (AISSEE); NCC; fitness; keep Maths and Science strong
After Class 10	Agniveer (age 17.5-21) or continue Class 11-12 (PCM for technical entries)
After Class 12	NDA, Army TES / Navy BTech (JEE Main), Agniveer Technical / Clerk
After graduation	CDS, AFCAT, NCC Special Entry, technical graduate entries
Selection	Written test or JEE rank, then 5-day SSB and medical
Career	Officer, Agniveer / JCO, defence support roles, second career in CAPF / civil services

Exam / route	When	Pattern / key point	Marking
AISSEE	Jan (2026: 18 Jan)	Class 6 and 9; offline OMR; 150 / 180 min	Check notice
NDA	Twice a year (II: 13 Sep 2026)	Maths 300 + GAT 600; SSB 900	1/3 negative
CDS	Twice a year (I: 11 Apr 2027)	English, GK, Maths (OTA: 2 papers)	Check notification
AFCAT	Twice a year (2: 8 Aug 2026)	100 Q, 120 min online	Negative marking
Navy 10+2 / Army TES	Yearly; JEE Main based	70% PCM (Navy) / 60% PCM (Army)	JEE rank + SSB
Agniveer	Yearly notifications	Age 17.5-21; 4-year service	Entrance + physical

Key rules: officer entries are for unmarried candidates; Air Force / Navy / technical entries need Physics and Maths; every officer entry ends in the 5-day SSB.†

Scholarships: NMMS (Class 8), CSSS (UG), wards-of-servicemen scholarships.†

Careers: Army / Navy / Air Force officer, Agniveer, JCO, JAG, defence medical, CAPF, civil services.

Want a personalised roadmap or counselling? Contact LessonPlan, Yelahanka, Bangalore.

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